

Live-Commerce Operating Platform Case Study

The Platform Merchants and Creators Ran Their Live-Commerce Business On

One-line judgement: Merchants and creators weren't short of tools — they were short of **one platform**. I built Baidu's live-commerce operating platform **0-to-1** — where a merchant or creator runs their entire live business (products, content, talent-merchant collaboration, marketing, campaigns and data) from one surface. Comparable in scope to TikTok Shop's merchant and creator platform.

Role & Scope

Role: Lead Product Manager — built the control centre 0-to-1

Product: Baidu's live-commerce operating platform for merchants and creators (a £2M+ daily GMV business) — built 0-to-1.

Scope: Product strategy, workflow consolidation, information architecture, seller/operator research, adoption, cross-functional delivery with engineering, design and operations.

Context

Running a live-commerce business as a seller means juggling several jobs at once — the account, the products, the live content, and the marketing. On many platforms these live in separate tools, so operators tab-hop, lose context and make mistakes under the time pressure of a live broadcast.

Problem

The problem was not **"sellers need more features."** It was:

"An operator has to run account, product, content and marketing across four disconnected surfaces — during a live broadcast when there's no time to switch context."

Fragmentation is a tax paid every single broadcast. The opportunity was to remove it.

Insight

For a B2B operating tool, the win is not a standout feature — it's **becoming the single surface the operator works from all day**. Whether operators keep coming back is the honest test of whether you achieved that.

Strategic Decisions

- 1. Unify account, product, content and marketing into one console.** Rather than add another standalone tool, I consolidated the seller's core workflows into a single control centre — so the operator sets up, runs and adjusts a live business without leaving one surface.
- 2. Design around the live-broadcast moment, not a calm back office.** The console had to work under the time pressure of a running live room, where a missed step costs sales — which drove the information architecture and the "one place" bet.
- 3. Judge success by whether operators return, not by feature count.** For an operating tool, the honest test is whether it becomes the surface operators run their day from. It collapsed broadcaster onboarding from **72 hours to under a minute** and grew **monthly active merchants +116%**, while materially reducing operational effort per cycle.

Trade-offs

The core trade-off was **consolidation vs. modular simplicity**. Separate, single-purpose tools are simpler to build and ship independently; one unified console is harder to design and to keep coherent as it grows. I chose consolidation because the operator's real problem was fragmentation itself — and a slightly more complex product that ends context-switching beats four simple tools that don't.

Outcomes & Impact

- Consolidated **account, product, content and marketing** workflows into a single seller/operator console.
- Collapsed **broadcaster onboarding from 72 hours to under a minute** — a step-change in how fast the platform could bring sellers live.
- Grew **monthly active merchants +116%** — evidence the console became the surface sellers actually returned to.
- Materially **reduced operational effort per cycle**, lowering the cost of running a live-commerce business on the platform.

What I Learned

- **For B2B operating tools, "one place" can be the whole product.** Removing fragmentation is often worth more than any individual feature.
- **Repeat use is the honest KPI for an operating surface.** Onboarding speed and returning merchants measure whether you actually became part of the operator's day.
- **Design for the hardest moment.** Building for the pressure of a live broadcast, not a calm back office, is what made the console trustworthy in real use.